MAHATMA GANDHI UNIVERSITY, KOTTAYAM

Third Semester MGU-UGP (Honours)Regular Examination November 2025

Discipline Specific Course – MG3DSCENG200

An Introduction to Phonetics

(2024 Admission Onwards)

Model Question Paper

Duration: 2 Hours Maximum Marks: 70

Students should attempt at least one question from each course outcome to enhance their overall outcomeattainability.

Part A

Multiple Choice Questions

Answer all questions. Each question carries 1 mark.

1. Who developed the Cardinal Vowel system? [K] [2]
   a. Ferdinand de Saussure
   b. Daniel Jones
   c. Alexander Graham Bell
   d. Richard Ogden
2. Identify the region where Proto-Indo-European was primarily spoken? [K] [1]
   a. Mediterranean Basin
   b. Pontic-Caspian Steppe
   c. Indus Valley
   d. Mesopotamia
3. Which of the following is NOT a place of articulation? [U] [3]
   a. Bilabial b. Fricative c. Velar d. Palatal
4. In the word introspection, where is the primary stress? [U] [4]
   a. First syllable
   b. Second syllable
   c. Third syllable
   d. Fourth syllable
5. Identify the common diphthong sound in the words ‘tear, bear’. [U] [2]
   a. /eɪ/ b. /aʊ/ c. /eə/ d. /aɪ/
6. Which of the following is an example of a minimal pair? [U] [3]
   a. pin – pen
   b. pin – pinning
   c. pit – put
   d. spin – spoon
7. In the sentence, “I didn’t say he stole the money,” shifting the nucleus changes [U] [4]
   a. Stress pattern only
   b. Meaning and speaker intent
   c. Intonation type
   d. Grammar
8. What is meant by "stricture of open approximation" in vowel production? [U] [2]
   a. The tongue touches the roof of the mouth completely.
   b. There is complete closure in the vocal tract.
   c. The tongue approaches the roof of the mouth leaving space for smooth airflow.
   d. The lips are tightly closed to block airflow.
9. Verner’s Law was formulated to explain exceptions in _____ [U] [1]

a. Vowel shifts
b. Grimm's Law
c. Lexical diffusion
d. Paradigms

10. In the word "splendid," identify the onset of the first syllable. [A] [3]
    a. /s/
    b. /sp/
    c. /spl/
    d. /splend/

(10 × 1 = 10 Marks)

Part B

Short Essay Questions

Answer any six questions in about 100 words. Each question carries 5 marks.

11. Define phoneme and allophone. Providing one example for each from English. Explain how they differ in function. [K] [3]
12. What is stress? Explain the functions of stress with examples. [U] [4]
13. Explain the major applications of phonetics in everyday life? [U] [1]
14. Explain pure vowels and diphthongs with reference to English. [U] [2]
15. Analyse the syllable structure of the word 'strategy' identifying the onset, nucleus, and coda. [A] [3]
16. Explain key intonation patterns providing examples. [U] [4]
17. Describe the main branches of phonetics. [U] [1]
18. Explain the significance of the Cardinal Vowel System. [U] [2]
19. Compare and contrast plosives and affricates. Provide two examples each along with the three-part descriptions. [U] [3]

(6 × 5 = 30 Marks)

Part C

Essay Questions

Answer any two in 300 words each.

20. Write an essay on the human speech organs with the help of a labelled diagram. [U] [1]
21. How are diphthongs classified in English RP? Explain their classification with examples. [U] [2]
22. Analyse how syllable structure and consonant clusters function in English phonology, examining their key characteristics and patterns of distribution. [U] [3]
23. Transcribe the following passage: [A] [4]

Student: (enters after being called) Good morning, sir!

Dean: Good morning. Please be seated. So, you are N S Dharan.

Student: Yes, sir.

Dean: You have applied for BA English (Hons.) Programme.

Student: Yes, sir.

Dean: Where did you complete your schooling from?

Student: Modern Public School, Kottayam.

Dean: (Reads from transcripts) 90% in aggregate and 94% in English. 'Impressive'!

Student: Thank you, sir.

Dean: What made you choose this college?

Student: Well sir, yours is one of the most reputed colleges in Central Travancore.
Besides, English and Economics Departments are especially good here.

Dean: How do you know that?

Student: Sir, I have friends who have studied here.

Dean: Then you must also know that there are a lot of extra-curricular activities.

Student: I know that sir. I'm fond of dramatics and debating.
I was also the editor of my school magazine.

Dean: You have scored good marks in mathematics. Why didn't you join that?

Student: English with Economics fascinates me. They're my favourites.

Dean: You have completed the formalities.

Student: Thank you, sir.

(2 × 15 = 30 Marks)